

CHAMBAL SANCTUARY

SHIFTING SANDS

gharial, besides a large number of migratory birds that visit in winter. The sanctuary, with one of the most pristine major rivers of north India as its beating heart, was first notified in 1978 on the MP side, with UP and Rajasthan following up.

That history turned a bit in December 2021, when the MP government moved a proposal to denotify 292 hectares (2.92 sq. km) of the sanctuary at five sites in the state—two each in Morena and Sheopur districts and one in Bhind. Responding to the proposal submitted to the Centre, the standing committee of the National Board for Wildlife (NBWL), including former Indian Forest Service officer H.S. Singh and National Tiger Conservation Authority secretary S.P. Yadav, toured the sites proposed for denotification in the latter half of June this year. "I can't say anything about the standing committee's decision on this until the report is finalised," says Singh.

Though this is not the first time a case has been made out to denotify parts of the sanctuary, the rationale behind the latest proposal—the state government's acceptance of the ground realities vis-à-vis illegal sand mining—makes it interesting. "There is a local demand for sand, which will have to be met from somewhere. It is best to denotify some areas to enable legal mining there, so that the rest of the sanctuary can be effectively protected," says J.S. Chauhan, chief wildlife warden, MP. In other words, the government hopes that once certain areas are removed from the sanctuary and made available for legal harvesting of river sand, the areas that remain within the sanctuary would remain unmolested. There's another assumption behind this hope: that the entire sand mining currently happening illegally in these areas is for meeting the needs of the local population and not the greed of sand miners.



CHAITHANYA KRISHNAN

LAST OF THE SKIMMERS?
The Chambal is a key nesting site for the endangered Indian Skimmer (6,000 left)

Not everyone agrees with this rationale, of course. Among the critics is former NBWL member Prerna Bindra. "If the government cannot control a crime, the answer lies not in legalising it but in more focused, vigorous efforts to curb it. I hope this does not portend that the government will follow the same logic for other crimes," says Bindra. Pointing out that the National Chambal Sanctuary is home to at least three endangered species and the river banks serve as a